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Accounting for the Reflective Shift in Aquinas's Theory of Cognition

In Aquinas's hierarchy of being, humans have the distinction of spanning the threshold between the animal kingdom and the higher genus of intellectual substances. Man's hybrid being and nascence among intellectual substances accounts for his peculiar cognitive apparatus. His immaterial intellect depends for its cognition upon likenesses abstracted from material surroundings and as a consequence he finds himself unable to cognize either separate immaterial substances or material singulars directly but only, as it were, through a system of mirrors. Even his own intellect can only be perceived through a reflective process. While it is in the nature of intellects understand their own understanding (*ST. Ia.87.3*, 15-20), man's foregoing dependence on material things disrupts his reflective circuit. The objects of the world preoccupy his attention, but without fully blocking some kind of perception of his own thoughts and self, which are subsequently capable of being brought into sharper focus. This essay concerns this reflective shift. While Aquinas at times suggests that reflective cognition is somehow integrated with the cognition of extramental objects, his overall theory does not seem to allow for the concurrence of multiple intentions (in this case, the object-intention and the reflective-intention). This apparent tension has lead many interpreters to render Aquinas's account of reflective cognition as fundamentally obscure. In attempting to elucidate Aquinas's account of the reflective shift, then, my approach will be to (1) outline the parameters of Aquinas's account of reflection and locate the interpretive difficulty by way of Robert Pasnau's analysis, (2) follow Therese Scarpelli-Cory in attempting to resolve the difficulty based on the recognition and reconciliation of

explicit and implicit kinds of reflective awareness in Aquinas's theory, and briefly explicate Aquinas's position in this new light.

1.

In our daily lives, we regularly experience the following phenomenon: while following the primary narrative of our day (say, having a conversation), we sometimes shift into what feels like a self-reflective meta-narrative (“Why is he looking at me strangely? Have I been rude?”). Sooner or later, perhaps having adjusted our outlook, we settle back into the primary flow of things. This ordinary rhythm presents a challenging case for a theory of cognition. The reflective shift has two basic characteristics:

(1) It is experienced as a *temporal sequence*, in three stages: first, the primary narrative, then the reflective narrative, and then the primary narrative.

(2) The stages involve some kind of *reference*. I leave the boundaries of this characteristic vague since they will turn out to offer different interpretations but, at the least, the reflective narrative somehow retains access to the primary narrative inasmuch as the reflective narrative is experienced as a modification of the primary narrative.

The challenge for a theory of cognition, then, is to account for a sort of *cognitive shifting capacity*, over and above the capacity of tracking from one object to another.

The parameters of Aquinas's account of reflection are as follows. Human-beings are capable of thinking in an unlimited universal mode, and so qualify as having immaterial intellects, but evidently depend on material likenesses for their cognition, and so must only participate in this genus as *potential* (*ST. Ia.87.1, 35-50*). They require sensory phantasms as fuel to power their intellect (*ST.*

Ia.87.1, 50-60). This feature has the following corollary: it is only when the intellect is provided sufficient fuel, and is sparked to *think-some-thing* that it itself gains actual presence and becomes available as an object of thought. The *object understood* and the *intellect understanding* are manifested at the same time, already mutually engaged, in *thought-about-something*. The human intellect, however, is oriented at material “primarily” and toward its intellectual acts only “secondarily” (*ST.* Ia.87.3, 30-40). That is to say, the co-manifestation is by default trained toward the object rather than the intellect. Humans are then able to cognize their own intellectual structure, somehow, by way of *reflexio* (“bending back”). This proceeds from the outside in, progressively discerning more fundamental manifestations of the intellect; the 'thought about the thought' and the 'thought about myself' are different stages along this same reflective axis. While a precise articulation of these workings is the business of philosophers and scientists, ordinary reflective perception follows from the mere presence of the intellect (*ST.* Ia.87.1, 70-80). So, then, how does Aquinas account for our familiar experience of shifting from a *thought-about-something* to a *thought-about-my-thought* or a *thought-about-myself*?

Robert Pasnau offers the following interpretation. Aquinas's various statements to the effect that the human intellect cognizes its material object primarily and its act only secondarily are clearly intended to mean, more than a mere temporal relation of *sequence*, an evidential or causal relation of *dependence* (341). Aquinas, however, prohibits against the simultaneous comprehension of multiple things under different intellectual species (at 85.4), and seems to identify the object and the reflection thereof as different things (at 87.3 ad. 2: “...there is one act by which the intellect understands a stone, and another act by which it understands that it understands the stone”) (341-2). This relation of dependence, then, can not mean the *concurrence* of the secondary understanding with the primary. Pasnau provides a case study which illustrates the difficulty (345-7). Suppose an initial thought “the cheese is moldy” and two possible subsequent thoughts: (a) “I bought the cheese two weeks ago” and

(b) “I am thinking the cheese is moldy”. In one sense, each possible transition is equally seamless: they each require a simple shift of attention (as from one object in my field of vision to another). In another, they are different: *a* is merely prompted by the initial thought, while *b* seems to depend on continued “reliable access” to it, or “grounding” by it. Inasmuch as Aquinas means the reflection to have a strong “evidential or causal” relation to its object-thought, he is committed to maintaining that reflective shifts are like the transition to *b*. Yet how is this dependency requirement of continued reliable access to the original perception ultimately reconciled with the rejection of the possible concurrence of a reflection with its original object-perception? What is the principle of unification between these two disparate intentions?

With this ambiguity in mind, Pasnau raises “a paradox about self-knowledge”: our reflections *seem* to be simultaneous with their primary thought and yet are always observed to occur at a temporal remove: “I can know what I thought a moment ago, but I can never know what I am thinking” (346). Properly speaking, it seems, one can only say “I *was* thinking about cheese.” On this evidence, Pasnau resolves the problem by suggesting that Aquinas's dependence characteristic must be weakened. A proponent of skepticism could justifiably argue, from Aquinas's own premises on the matter, that all cognitions which seem to retain a dependence or access to their “grounding” cognition are, properly speaking, exclusive and independent, with their apparent relation of dependency being only epiphenomenal. Pasnau, however, proposes that the reliable access and grounding condition can be satisfied by a “broader conception of knowledge” which would locate the grounding cognition as “knowledge” stored in the intellectual disposition, not presently had in mind but ready to be retrieved (346-7). Aquinas's evidential or causal claim for the dependence of a reflection upon its grounding thought, then, appears theoretically uncertain, rationalizing interpretations both sympathetic and unsympathetic to his overall project.

2.

For Scarpelli-Cory, the concurrency dilemma that Pasnau raises is not the result of an intractable theoretical obscurity in Aquinas's account, but only technical obscurities, capable of being brought to light. The resolution has two phases: first, establishing that for Aquinas *every* “explicit” object-cognition involves an “implicit” reflective awareness, and vice versa, and second, determining the principle unifying the transition between the explicit object-cognition and the subsequent explicit reflection thereof.

Across a widespread selection of texts, Aquinas sometimes (in the “A” texts) suggests that reflection is intrinsic to thought of an extramental object (e.g. “Whoever understands... cognizes himself to understand... because he cognizes the thing to be manifest to himself” at *ST. Ia.111.1*, ad 3), and other times (in the “B” texts) suggest that each reflective act is numerically distinct (e.g. “The soul does not always think about itself” at *ST. Ia.93.7*, ad 4) (142-3). The presence of such apparently conflicting statements leads to a critical tendency to prioritize one or the other selection of texts, especially the more numerous “B” texts. Rather than assuming the priority of either account, Scarpelli-Cory suggests the plausible alternative that the former group depicts *implicit reflection* and the latter group *explicit reflection*. Such a claim is not inconsistent with the phenomena. Scarpelli-Cory emphasizes the retrospective evidence of the presence of implicit reflection in explicit object cognition. She gives the example of a gardener encountering a toad:

[W]hile engrossed in watching the toad, the gardener was nevertheless not wholly oblivious to herself. Suppose that she spends the whole time watching the toad and never once turns her attention to herself: If an onlooker then asks her what she had been doing in the garden, she will recall not just the toad but *herself watching the toad*, and she can articulate that experience as a statement *about herself*, the conscious subject. “Oh, just then? I was watching the toad eating insects.” In order for this assertion to be possible at all, it seems that her

cognition of the toad must have included some sort of embedded grasp of herself-as-thinker, which went unnoticed at the time but could be retrieved later in remembering the original experience. (134-5)

It seems that in engaging with the world, one maintains an ongoing implicit reflective reference, which is capable of being amplified to explicitness.

In substantiating that Aquinas holds such a view, Scarpelli-Cory begins by establishing the function of implicit cognition in general for Aquinas. To be clear, Aquinas does not allow any intellectual operation to be implicit in any sense of “trailing alongside” an attentive operation, because the intellectual operation is nothing less than the actual assimilation of the possible intellect to its object (137). Rather, the object's peculiar manifestation to the intellect in a given circumstance belies a certain set of relations to other intelligibles. Scarpelli-Cory provides two cases, “Participated Attention” and “Implicit Cognition”. “Participated Attention” concerns the intellect's power to conjoin multiple intelligibles into a single complex whole: for instance, a painting (138-40). While the whole is what is understood “primarily” under a single intention, the understanding implies a concomitant but non-primary actualization of the distinct parts that it organizes into a unity: for instance, the various things represented in a painting. It is “Implicit Cognition”, however, that provides the critical clue for drawing out the mechanisms of implicit reflection.

Implicit cognition functions as follows. For Aquinas, the object and its formalizing principle are received in a single operation, under a single intention:

Every power is directed to its object and to the formal notion of the object by one operation or one act. For example, by the same sight we see light and color, which becomes visible in act through light. Now, when we will something solely for the sake of the end, that which is desired for the sake of the end derives the nature of something willed from the end; and thus

the end is to it as the formal notion of the object is to the object, for example, as light is to color. (*SCG* 1.76.1)

In *seeing* an apple, I necessarily see the light that is illuminating it and, similarly, in *desiring* an apple, my desire is shaped by the end that is constituting it as desirable to me. Cory renders this rule as “the principle thesis”: “[w]henever an intentional operation is directed to something, it ipso facto attains, implicitly, whatever formally actualizes that thing as a suitable object for such an operation” (140). In studying a scene painting, its appearance is constituted by factors such as the light (which might be an unusual hue) and even my hierarchy of motivations for studying the scene painting at all, which are not articulated as “parts” in my cognition of the scene painting itself.

The principle thesis is the linchpin for Cory's account of implicit reflective awareness in Aquinas. In effect, the formalizing principle and its object are related as form to a material – a single entity perceived under a single intention. This suggests two complementary aspects of the way in which cognition of an object implies an integrated implicit reflective awareness. The first aspect follows upon the analogy of physical light and intellectual light. For Aquinas, the illuminating intellectual light in question belongs to the individual's private *agent intellect*. Thus, following the principle thesis, when an intellect apprehends an essence illuminated by his agent intellect, he apprehends his own illuminating agent intellect, in the same implicit way he apprehends the lighting conditions when studying a painting. The second aspect follows upon the identity between the object and the *possible intellect* in act. At the moment of cognition, the intelligible-in-act (the possible intellect) is identical with the intelligible-object-in-act, which suggests that to be thinking an object or essence is also somehow to be thinking one's own possible intellect. The cognition of an object manifests, together, the object and the intellect-thinking-about-that-object. This cognition, however, is still implicit in the sense suggested by the principle thesis. The persistence of myself as a receptive locus functions as a

formalizing principle through which I perceive objects. When studying a painting I not only apprehend the lighting conditions, but apprehend them *as directed to myself*. Any intellect's foregoing cognition of some extramental essence, then, involves these two complementary aspects of self-reflection, experienced only in the way of formalizing principles: first, toward the agent intellect, the active principle by which the intellect enables itself to understand (constituting the ongoing feeling of "agency"), and, second, toward the possible intellect, the passive principle by which the intellect is continuously adapted to the objects it comes into contact with (constituting the ongoing feeling of "subjectivity") (162).

So much for implicit reflection occurrent on explicit cognition of an extramental object, but what about when a reflection is raised to explicit attention, as in Aquinas's "B" texts? The intellect is only made available for cognition when actualized by thinking some material thing. This principle of co-manifestation suggests that, as the formalizing influence of the intellect is implicitly perceived in any object-directed cognition, any explicit reflective cognition will somehow involve the implicit perception of the determining influence of the actualizing object. The obstacle to such an approach is that explicit object-cognition and explicit reflective-cognition constitute different acts (recall, e.g., "the understanding of the stone" and "the understanding of the understanding of the stone"), and Aquinas prohibits against the simultaneous comprehension of multiple things under different intellectual species (at 85.4). It was precisely this difficulty that forced Pasnau to locate the unifying reference between the object-cognition and the reflective-cognition in dispositional knowledge.

The key technical point for Scarpelli-Cory's clarification is that, for Aquinas:

[T]he intentionality of a given intellectual act is governed by two principles, both of which sometimes go under the name 'intention': the species being *used* (which specifies a range of intelligible content), and the *direction* of intellectual attention (which determines the intellect

to *some aspect* of the intelligibility made present via the species. A single species-intention can support many attention-intentions, like a multipurpose instrument. For instance, one might think of a man as rational, teachable, living, mammalian, in distinct acts, all using a single species of man... In short, the range of thoughts that I can have is delimited by the species I use, but *what I think about within that specified range* (the-object-under-a-specific-aspect) is determined by how I choose to direct my attention. (164)

The shift from an (explicit) object cognition to an (explicit) reflection thereof *does not involve a change of intellectual species*. Aquinas is clear that reflection depends, not on an intellectual species of its own, but on that of its extramental object: "the human intellect, which is actualized through the species of the object understood, is understood through that same species, as through its own form" (*ST* Ia.87.1 ad 3). This persistence of the intellectual species evades the prohibition on multiple objects of cognition at 85.4: "The intellect can think about more than one thing by way of one thing but not by way of more than one thing. In saying "by way of one or more things," I mean by one or several intelligible species". Thus, a single presently held intellectual species can provide the principle of unity allowing for some sort of shift *from* the explicit object cognition and implicit reflective awareness *to* the explicit reflective cognition and implicit object awareness.

We are now in a position to better explicate what Aquinas means by reflection. Assuming an ongoing grasp of a given intellectual species, there are two kinds of directional intentional shifts an intellect might undertake. First, it might rove between the various parts of a complex object, dwelling on a particular element without losing sight of the broader calibration of elements the given whole entails. Such roving belongs to the kind of implicit understanding identified earlier as "Participated Attention". Second, it might (somehow) come to perceive a previously *implicit* formalizing principle of its object, and (somehow) incorporate that into its attentive focus. This incorporation shifts something

understood implicitly in the sense of “Implicit Cognition” to something understood implicitly in the sense of “Participated Attention”. Such as shift uproots something previously implicit and renders it explicit, as for example realizing the influence of a light glaring on a painting. To (explicitly) reflect is, precisely, to integrate a formalizing *principle* of one's object cognition, specifically an intellectual formalizing principle, into the organization of articulated *parts* of the object of cognition.

Now, how exactly this integration occurs is not obvious. The human intellect is an immaterial essence. When made perceptually explicit, it has no direct sensuous or material analogue. Reflection is experienced less, then, like having aspects of one's self lain among other perceptibles as if parts to be studied together on a table, and more like a sustained concentration upon the relevant parts, or cues, which prompted the perception of the implicit formalizing principle. It is as if, facing the painting, one realizes that the glare whitening many of the colors is not intrinsic to the painting itself but a feature of a light set behind one's field of vision, *but in this realization never steps back to study the light fixture and the painting in the same sight*. In this respect, Scarpelli-Cory's analogy of the reflective shift to a sudden awareness of a previously unnoticed *detail* (i.e., part) in the painting (169) seems less felicitous than Pasnau's characterization of reflection as “a certain way of looking at external things” (343). Scarpelli-Cory's analogy fits the case of the inference of a formalizing principle in general, but not of an intellectual formalizing principle specifically. So then, insofar as the glare remains perceptually highlighted, those structural elements intrinsic to the painting are pushed to the background, and those which triggered the awareness of the glare are held into focus. It is only when the influence of the glare is acknowledged and adjusted for, or otherwise left to slip, that the painting is allowed back into its former proportions.

When the human intellect attends to an object, the agent intellect abstracts an intellectual species from the object which acts as a sort of universalizing lens to enable the possible intellect to be exposed and assimilated to the object's essence. The understood object, including its

articulated parts, is always reflective of the principles constituting its formation. So long as this species holds and the intellect is actualized, this reflection may, further, be potentially raised to attention. When this occurs, the object and its relevant parts are used as a mirror to peer into the intellectual apparatus. This is presumably by somehow stressing or centering those parts of the complex object most indicative of the given aspect of the apparatus, but such a determination requires further inquiry.